ENG504 SHORT HANDOUTS MIDTERM

Lesson 01 to 05

(ENG504) Second Language Acquisition

EFFORT BY VUHELPERS24 TEAM

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Lesson-01

INTRODUCTION TO SECOND LANGUAGE ACQUISITION

Topic 001: Introduction to SLA

What does SLA stand for?

SLA stands for Second Language Acquisition.

How is SLA different from language teaching?

SLA focuses on learners and learning, while language teaching focuses on teachers and teaching.

When does the acquisition of a second language typically occur?

Second language acquisition usually occurs after a person has acquired their first language.

What does SLA stand for, and how does it differ from language teaching?

SLA, which stands for Second Language Acquisition, is a research field that centers on learners and their language learning processes rather than on teachers and teaching methods. Unlike language teaching, which focuses on instructional techniques, SLA seeks to understand how individuals internalize the linguistic system of another language and utilize it in comprehension and speech production.

Topic 002: Key Concepts

What are the key questions that SLA seeks to answer?

SLA aims to answer questions about how learners acquire another language's linguistic system and how they use it for comprehension and speech production.

What fundamental questions does SLA aim to address?

SLA seeks to address fundamental questions about how learners come to internalize the linguistic system of a second language and how they apply that linguistic knowledge when they engage in understanding and producing speech in that language. It delves into the processes and mechanisms of language acquisition.

Topic 003: What Makes a Good Theory

Why is a good theory important in SLA?

A good theory in SLA is crucial for explaining and understanding how language acquisition works.

Why is it essential for SLA theories to meet certain criteria?

SLA theories must meet specific criteria because they serve as the foundation for understanding and explaining language acquisition processes. A good theory should be clear, explicit, and testable. It needs to provide insights into the mechanisms of language acquisition and facilitate empirical research to advance our understanding of second language learning.

Topic 004: Types of Theories

What is "property theory" in SLA?

Property theory in SLA focuses on the structure of language and how it changes over time.

What does "transition theory" study in SLA?

Transition theory in SLA explores the different stages of language learning and development.

How does "property theory" differ from "transition theory" in the context of SLA?

"Property theory" in SLA focuses on examining the structure of language and understanding how languages evolve and change over time. In contrast, "transition theory" is primarily concerned with studying the developmental stages of language education, both in the context of first language acquisition and second language learning. Transition theory explores how individuals progress through various stages in their language development journey and may draw comparisons between first and second language acquisition processes.

Topic 005: Evaluating a Theory of SLA

What are some criteria for evaluating a theory of SLA?

A good theory of SLA should be clear, testable, and provide explanations for language acquisition.

What are some important criteria used to evaluate theories of SLA?

To assess the quality and validity of theories in the field of SLA, several criteria are applied. These include the theory's clarity and explicitness, its ability to make testable predictions, and its capacity to provide explanations for observed language acquisition phenomena. Additionally, theories in SLA should be grounded in empirical research and open to refinement through ongoing investigation.

Topic 006: Views on the Nature of Language

Why is language considered the most important phenomenon in the world?

Language is crucial because it regulates all human activities and is the primary means of communication.

How is learning a language different from acquiring other skills?

Learning a language is a skill that requires practice, unlike some skills that are acquired naturally.

Why is language considered rule-governed?

Language follows specific rules, such as sentence structure, which vary from language to language.

What makes each language unique?

Each language is unique due to its distinct sounds, vocabulary, and structures.

Why is language often regarded as the most important phenomenon in human life?

Language is considered the most vital phenomenon in human life because it governs and regulates virtually all human activities from birth to death. It serves as the primary means of communication, enabling individuals to express thoughts, feelings, and emotions to others. Without language, the complex societies that humans have built would be impossible. Language is a fundamental aspect that distinguishes humans from other species, as it facilitates connections between past, present, and future generations.

What makes language learning unique compared to other skills?

Language learning is distinct from other skills like swimming or cycling in that it is not acquired naturally through mere exposure. Instead, it is a skill subject that requires rigorous practice and active engagement. Learning a language involves developing major linguistic skills like listening, speaking, reading, and writing, and mastery comes through repetition and active use.

Why is language considered rule-governed, and what is an example of this?

Language is considered rule-governed because it adheres to specific sets of rules or grammar. For example, in English, sentence structure typically follows the pattern of Subject-Verb-Object (SVO), where the subject precedes the verb, and the object

follows the verb. These rules govern how sentences are formed in the language, and similar rules exist in all languages, each with its own unique system.

What sets each language apart and makes them unique?

Each language is unique because it possesses distinct features related to its sounds, vocabulary, and grammatical structures. These characteristics are influenced by the culture and history of the language-speaking community, leading to variations in pronunciation, word choices, and sentence structures across different languages. These linguistic idiosyncrasies contribute to the uniqueness of each language.

Lesson-02

NATURE OF LANGUAGE, MODULARITY AND LANGUAGE VARIABILITY

Topic 007: Views on the Nature of Language - Competence and Performance

What is the main focus of Noam Chomsky's interest in language study?

Noam Chomsky's main focus is on competence in language.

Define competence in the context of language according to Chomsky.

Competence refers to the abstract and hidden representation of language knowledge inside minds, enabling the creation and understanding of original utterances.

Why is studying competence challenging?

Competence is challenging to study because language performance data are imperfect reflections of it, and competence can only be indirectly assessed under controlled conditions.

What is the main focus of Noam Chomsky's interest in language study?

Noam Chomsky's primary focus in language study is on competence, which refers to the abstract and hidden representation of language knowledge inside minds.

Competence enables individuals to create and understand original utterances in a given language.

Define competence in the context of language according to Chomsky.

Competence, as described by Chomsky, is the internalized and latent knowledge of language that enables individuals to generate and comprehend sentences in their native language. It represents the underlying, innate linguistic structure that speakers possess.

Why is studying competence challenging?

Studying competence is challenging because language performance, which consists of actual language use, often does not fully reflect the intricacies of competence. Competence can only be assessed indirectly under controlled conditions, as language performance data can be imperfect and influenced by various factors.

Topic 008: The Language Learning Process - Nature vs. Nurture

Who advocated for behaviorist mechanisms in language learning?

Answer: B. F. Skinner advocated for behaviorist mechanisms in language learning.

What did Noam Chomsky emphasize in the nature vs. nurture debate?

Chomsky emphasized the role of innate dispositions and Universal Grammar (UG) in language acquisition.

Explain the nature vs. nurture debate in language learning.

The debate revolves around whether language learning is primarily influenced by innate factors (nature) or environmental factors (nurture).

Who advocated for behaviorist mechanisms in language learning?

B. F. Skinner advocated for behaviorist mechanisms in language learning. He emphasized the role of environmental factors and conditioning in shaping language acquisition.

What did Noam Chomsky emphasize in the nature vs. nurture debate?

In the nature vs. nurture debate, Noam Chomsky emphasized the role of innate dispositions and the existence of Universal Grammar (UG). He argued that humans have an inborn capacity for language and that language is organized according to specific universal principles.

Explain the nature vs. nurture debate in language learning.

The nature vs. nurture debate in language learning centers on whether language acquisition is primarily influenced by innate factors (nature) or environmental factors (nurture). Those who lean toward the "nature" side believe that humans have inherent language-learning abilities, while proponents of "nurture" emphasize the influence of external factors, such as exposure and conditioning.

Topic 009: The Language Learning Process - Modularity

According to Piaget, is language acquisition a special process?

No, Piaget believed that language is not a special process but rather one manifestation of a general skill of symbolic representation.

How does Chomsky view language acquisition in terms of complexity?

Chomsky believes that language is too complex to be learned solely from environmental exposure and requires distinctive mechanisms, such as Universal Grammar.

What is Universal Grammar, as described by Chomsky?

Universal Grammar is a theory proposing that humans are born with an innate capacity for language and a set of grammatical rules shared across all languages.

According to Piaget, is language acquisition a special process?

According to Piaget, language acquisition is not a special process. He viewed language as one manifestation of a general skill of symbolic representation and did not believe it required any distinct or specialized mechanism.

How does Chomsky view language acquisition in terms of complexity?

Chomsky sees language acquisition as too complex to be solely learned from environmental exposure. He argues that language has a unique and intricate structure, making it unlikely to be acquired through general cognitive means. Chomsky proposes the existence of Universal Grammar (UG), which possesses its own distinctive mechanism for learning language.

What is Universal Grammar, as described by Chomsky?

Universal Grammar, as described by Chomsky, is a theoretical framework suggesting that humans are born with an innate capacity for language. UG includes a set of grammatical rules shared across all languages, forming the foundation for language acquisition and allowing individuals to structure sentences according to the rules of their specific language.

Topic 010: Modularity and SLA (Second Language Acquisition)

How do Behaviorists view errors in second language utterances?

Behaviorists view errors as the result of 'bad habits' that can be controlled through rote learning and pattern drilling using target language models.

What do recent studies suggest about errors and mistakes in second language acquisition?

Recent studies suggest that errors and mistakes in second language acquisition are patterned and not solely caused by first language influence.

Topic 011: System and Variability in SLA (Second Language Acquisition)

What characterizes a learner's language system in second language acquisition?

A learner's language system in second language acquisition is characterized by a high degree of variability.

Why is variability considered a central feature of learner interlanguage?

Variability is considered central because it reflects the dynamic nature of the language learning process and how learners adapt and refine their language skills over time.

Lesson-03

CREATIVITY AND SECOND LANGUAGE LEARNING

Topic 013: Creativity and Second Language Learning

What is the primary focus of creativity in the context of second language learning?

Creativity in second language learning is primarily about the process of understanding how the target language works through creative thinking.

How do learners' surface utterances relate to underlying rule systems in language learning?

Learners' surface utterances can be linked to underlying rule systems, even if they appear primitive and deviant compared to the target language system.

What role do formulas and routines play in everyday language use by native speakers?

Formulas and routines play an important role in everyday language use by native speakers.

Topic 014: Limited Learning and Fossilization

What does "fossilization" refer to in the context of second language learning?

Fossilization refers to the situation when a learner's second language system seems to 'freeze' or become stuck at some deviant stage.

Why do Second Language (SL) learners often differ noticeably from native speakers in pronunciation and grammar?

SL learners often remain noticeably different from native speakers in pronunciation and grammar because of incomplete success in language acquisition.

Topic 015: Psycholinguistic and Sociolinguistic Views

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How do psycholinguistic views and sociolinguistic views interpret the phenomena of limited learning and fossilization?

Psycholinguistic views suggest that language-specific learning mechanisms may cease to work for older SL learners, while sociolinguistic views propose that older SL learners may not have the social opportunities or motivation to identify with native communities, valuing their distinctive identity instead.

Topic 016: Cross-Linguistic Influences

What is the phenomenon known as "language transfer" in second language learning?

Language transfer refers to the influence of languages learners already know on their accent and characteristic mistakes in their utterances in a second language.

How do behaviorists and contemporary theorists differ in their views on language transfer?

Behaviorists view language transfer as a source of error and interference in SLL, while contemporary theorists hold widely differing views on the extent and nature of such influences.

What is the concept of "language transfer" in second language learning, and how does it impact learners' performance?

Language transfer refers to the influence of the languages learners already know on their accent and characteristic mistakes in their utterances in a second language. It can significantly impact learners' performance by introducing elements from their native language into the target language.

Topic 017: Second Language Use and Performance

What does "SL use" and "SL performance" refer to in the context of language learning?

SL use refers to the act of speaking and making sense of incoming language data, while SL performance involves interpreting and processing language data.

How do contemporary theorists emphasize the role of SL use in language learning?

Contemporary theorists argue that SL use plays a vital role in developing the skill component of language competence, which consists of both knowledge and skill components.

What does "SL use" and "SL performance" refer to in the context of language learning, and what role do they play in language development according to contemporary theorists?

"SL use" refers to speaking and making sense of incoming language data, while "SL performance" involves interpreting and processing language data. Contemporary theorists emphasize that both SL use and SL performance play a vital role in developing the skill component of language competence, which consists of both a knowledge component and a skill component. They argue that regular (oral) practice is essential for forming correct language 'habits' and developing language skills.

Lesson-04

SECOND LANUAGE USE AND PERFORMANCE PERSPECTIVE

Topic 019: Comprehensible Input Hypothesis

What is the Comprehensible Input Hypothesis?

It's the idea that language acquisition requires meaningful interactions and understanding, not grammar teaching.

Topic 020: Performance Perspective and Psycholinguistics

How does the Performance Perspective view second-language interaction?

It sees speaking and listening as integral and mutually influential in language learning.

Topic 021: Negative Evidence

What is negative evidence in the context of language learning?

Negative evidence informs learners about unacceptable forms in the target language, such as formal correction or informal paraphrasing.

Topic 022: Sociolinguistics

How does the Sociolinguistic perspective view language learning?

It sees language learning as essentially social, where identity and language knowledge are collaboratively constructed during interaction.

How does the Sociolinguistic perspective view language learning?

In the Sociolinguistic perspective, language learning is seen as a fundamentally social process. This perspective emphasizes that learners' identities and language knowledge are collaboratively constructed and reconstructed through interactions. The specific functions of these interactions may vary, from serving as apprenticeships to providing scaffolding for language acquisition.

Topic 023: Views of the Learner

What are the three main perspectives regarding the learner in second language learning?

The linguistic perspective, social psychological perspective, and socio-cultural perspective.

What are the three main perspectives regarding the learner in second language learning?

In second language learning, there are three primary perspectives regarding the learner:

The Linguistic Perspective: This perspective is primarily concerned with modeling language structures and the cognitive processes occurring within the learner's mind. It seeks to analyze and explain the developmental routes of language acquisition but tends to minimize or disregard social and contextual differences in the process.

The Social Psychological Perspective: This perspective focuses on modeling individual differences among learners and how these differences impact their eventual success in language learning. It delves into the individual characteristics and traits that contribute to language acquisition.

The Socio-Cultural Perspective: This perspective views learners as social beings who are members of social groups and networks. It places a strong emphasis on the social context of learning, where learners acquire language as they participate in social interactions and activities.

Topic 024: Linguistic Perspective

What does the linguistic perspective primarily focus on in language learning?

It focuses on modeling language structures and processes within the mind of the learner.

Topic 025: Social Psychological Perspective

What does the social psychological perspective concern itself with in language learning?

It focuses on modeling individual differences among learners and their implications for learning success.

How do the linguistic and social psychological perspectives differ in their approach?

The linguistic perspective focuses on mental mechanisms and developmental routes, while the social psychological perspective looks at individual differences and their impact on learning success.

What is the primary concern of the sociocultural perspective in language learning?

The sociocultural perspective sees learners as social beings and members of social groups and networks, emphasizing the social context of learning.

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Lesson 05

DIFFERENCE BETWEEN INDIVIDUAL LEARNERS

Topic No: 026-032

What are the two main categories of differences among individual language learners?

The two main categories are cognitive differences and affective differences.

What are some cognitive factors that contribute to individual differences in language learning?

Cognitive factors include intelligence, language aptitude, and language learning strategies.

What are some affective factors that contribute to individual differences in language learning?

Affective factors include language attitudes, motivation, language anxiety, and willingness.

How is the SL learner viewed in the context of social learning?

The SL learner is seen as a social being, and the social context in which learning takes place is considered, along with elements like social class, power, ethnicity, and gender.

How do the 'individual differences' tradition and socially oriented researchers view the relationship between the individual learner and the social context?

The 'individual differences' tradition sees the relationship as being governed by relatively fixed traits, while socially oriented researchers view factors like motivation and anxiety as constantly reconstructed.

What was the dominant learning theory in mainstream psychology during the 1950s and 1960s?

The dominant learning theory was 'Behaviourism.'

What approach did 'Progressive' language pedagogy in the 1950s draw upon, and what were its key principles?

Progressive language pedagogy drew upon a version of structuralism developed by British linguist Palmer. Its key principles included the belief in finite sets of language patterns, the idea that reception and practice lead to language habits, and teaching 'the basic' first before encouraging communication of learners' own thoughts and ideas.

Working on the Next Lessons

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